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COURSE WORK COVER SHEET

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TOPIC: Charles Burnett Killer of Sheep Essay

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FAM2004S

Essay 1: Charles Burnett Killer of Sheep

Scene analysed in *Killer of Sheep*: 02:50 – 05:33

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Charles Burnett's *Killer of Sheep* (1978) stands as one of the most moving portrayals of Black working-class life in American cinema. Set in the Watts neighbourhood of Los Angeles in the aftermath of the 1965 riots, the film captures the rhythms of ordinary life with a quiet poetry that resists spectacle and sentimentality. Rather than offering an overly open political narrative, Burnett turns his lens toward the subtle gestures, emotions, and moments that define daily existence, children playing in empty lots, couples sharing fleeting intimacy, neighbours exchanging jokes and care. This essay argues that *Killer of Sheep* uses neorealist aesthetics to represent love and tenderness as acts of endurance within a world of systemic neglect. Through a close analysis of the rock-throwing scene, it will show how Burnett transforms a seemingly mundane children's game into a visual metaphor for resilience, community, and affection within harsh circumstances.

Charles Burnett's *Killer of Sheep* (1978) is a black-and-white drama set in the Watts neighbourhood of Los Angeles. The film follows Stan, a quiet and hardworking man employed at a slaughterhouse, as he struggles with exhaustion, poverty, and a growing sense of emotional detachment from his family and community. The film unfolds through a series of everyday scenes that show life in a working-class Black community, children playing in empty lots, neighbours joking and helping one another, and families sharing small, tender moments at home. Made with non-professional actors and a minimal budget, *Killer of Sheep* captures the texture and rhythm of ordinary life with honesty and care. The film balances hardship and tenderness, revealing how love, humour, and resilience persist even in difficult circumstances.

The stylistic approach of *Killer of Sheep* owes much to Italian neorealism, a film movement that emerged in post-World War II Italy as a reaction to the artificiality of fascist propaganda cinema. Neorealist films often lean toward a populist left outlook and convey a sense of human unity. They typically focus on the lower classes but also include various civilians like farmers, students, and workers. With a documentary-like style, sometimes carefully constructed, they draw on real events or adapted literary sources, and often use non-professional actors to heighten realism(Lawton, 1979:11). They filmed on location, and focused on the working class to reveal humanity in the midst of hardship. Their goal was not merely to tell stories, but to show life as is. Burnett's film embodies this same spirit of truth-telling and simplicity.

Killer of Sheep adopts a distinctly different narrative style from that of traditional Hollywood genre films, aligning instead with the aesthetic and storytelling traits of classic Italian neorealism (Mehlinger, 2011:108). Burnett adapts neorealism to an American and distinctly Black context. His Watts is not postwar Rome, but the post-riot, economically damaged landscape of 1970s Los Angeles.

Burnett films in black and white, using natural light and the real homes, streets, and people of the community. The result is a form of realism that feels both documentary and poetic. Through this style, he captures the texture of Black life not as tragedy, but as something deeply human, full of humour, play, and care. Burnett's approach to realism both questions historical narratives and hints at what is to come(Maillard, 2017:327). This realism is political in itself because it reclaims the image of Black communities from the distortions of Hollywood and mainstream media, which often portrayed them only through violence, poverty, or stereotypes.

The rock-throwing scene occurs early in *Killer of Sheep* and is one of the most memorable moments in the film. A group of children gather in an open lot, a vacant space filled with broken walls, dust, and debris, evidence of the economic neglect left behind after the riots. The children split into two teams, standing opposite one another, and begin throwing rocks across the lot. The camera captures their movements in wide, medium, and close-up shots, following the rhythm of their play. At first glance, the game seems dangerous, even violent. But as the scene unfolds, Burnett transforms this apparent chaos into an image of community, resilience, and affection.

 [opening shot]

The scene opens with a medium close up shot of a young boy(Stan's son) hiding behind a block of wood, The space behind him is desolate, surrounded by fragments of concrete and scattered debris, visual reminders of the community's marginalization. Yet, within this wasteland, the children carve out their own world. Their laughter punctuates the silence, filling the space with life. The camera moves slowly and naturally, often handheld, observing rather than intruding. The framing allows the viewer to sense the dust, the light, and the uneven rhythm of their movements. This immediacy creates a feeling of being within the scene, not as a spectator, but as part of the community itself.

 [long shot with the background showing the bleak setting]

Burnett cuts between long shots, which capture the entire group, and medium close-ups, which isolate individual children's faces, expressions of joy, determination, and mischief. The alternation between these framings mirrors the rhythm of the game itself: throw, duck, laugh, pause. When a rock narrowly misses someone, the camera lingers for a moment, capturing both fear and relief, then shifts back to collective play. The editing is loose and unhurried, giving the sense that the camera is simply following life as it happens.

This natural pacing, combined with the absence of a musical score, enhances the realism of the moment. The soundtrack consists only of diegetic sounds of rocks striking the ground and children shouting. The soundscape becomes a kind of percussive rhythm, an improvised music of the everyday, echoing the notes of jazz and blues that run throughout the film. The children's laughter and movement generate their own melody, one born not of abundance but of survival.

In terms of composition, Burnett frequently frames the children in groups, emphasizing collectivity over individuality. There is no single protagonist here; the focus is on the dynamic between them, the sense of community forged through shared play. When one child is hit, the others stop, concerned but unpanicked. This pause reveals the underlying care and mutual understanding that governs their game. The momentary suspension of conflict, followed by laughter and resumed play becomes a small act of tenderness. Through this simple exchange, Burnett reveals how affection and empathy exist even within the roughness of childhood and the scarcity of the environment.

The contrast between the children's vitality and the bleak setting is central to the scene's meaning. The lot, filled with rubble and waste, symbolizes the social neglect of Watts, a place forgotten by the city and the state. Yet the children transform it into a playground, asserting imagination over decay. Their play becomes a form of resistance, a way of reclaiming space and dignity. This act echoes the core of neorealism: finding beauty in the ordinary, humanity within hardship.

Burnett's use of light further reinforces this tension between harshness and warmth. The midday sun casts strong shadows, accentuating the textures of dust and skin. The black-and-white

cinematography renders the scene timeless, placing it in a world that feels both specific and universal. The lack of colour draws attention to tone, texture, and motion to the physicality of the children and the material reality of their environment. The interplay of light and dust becomes almost lyrical, turning the neglected lot into a stage of poetic movement.

As the scene progresses, the camera gradually moves closer, capturing more intimate gestures like of a boy shielding his face and another laughing with eyes squeezed shut. These micro-expressions transform the children into fully realized subjects rather than background figures. Their faces, filmed with patience and empathy, reflect both innocence and awareness. Even in play, there is a sense of maturity, of knowing that joy must be created, not found.

 [shot of the children blocking the frame]

Burnett's visual approach emphasizes observation over manipulation. The camera never imposes meaning; it discovers it through proximity and duration. This can be seen in the scene as in most of the shots the children tend not to pay attention to the camera and instead continue to play and sometimes block the frame. This aligns with neorealist principles letting the scene breathe, allowing life to reveal itself. The result is an image that is both documentary and metaphorical. The children's game becomes a mirror of the community's endurance, they live within ruin but make it their own.

On a thematic level, the rock-throwing scene serves as an example of *Killer of Sheep*'s broader concern with love, resilience, and tenderness within a broken system. The children's play contrasts sharply with the emotional weariness of the adults in the film, particularly Stan, whose work in the slaughterhouse drains him both physically and spiritually. The adults live within the same environment, but their playfulness has been replaced by fatigue. Burnett uses this contrast to show how imagination and community can coexist with hardship, not as escapism, but as quiet resistance.

The relationship between children and adults becomes symbolic. The children represent the capacity for renewal, a continuation of life and hope even within decay. Their laughter, though fleeting, carries the echo of freedom that the adults have lost. The chaotic scenes of children running, fighting, throwing stones, and scheming reflect the actions of their adult counterparts, but while the children are full of energy, the adults are drained and weary (Maillard, 2017:323). Yet Burnett avoids

romanticizing this innocence; the children are still shaped by the same conditions of poverty and neglect. Their play takes place amid rubble, their joy coexists with danger. The fact that their game involves throwing rocks, instruments of potential harm, suggests that even love and tenderness in this world carry risk. This duality is central to Burnett's vision which is that beauty and pain are intertwined.

In this sense, the rock-throwing scene encapsulates the emotional logic of the film, that love is not sentimental but grounded in endurance. This can also be seen throughout the film through Stan's wife who endures and continues supporting her husband despite his apparent distance from his wife. The tenderness that exists between characters, whether in children's play or in Stan's quiet moments with his wife, is shaped by struggle. Burnett presents love as an act of persistence, an everyday choice to care in the face of despair. The children's game, full of laughter and dust, becomes a visual metaphor for this kind of love fragile, imperfect, but enduring.

Sound plays a crucial role in Burnett's construction of mood and meaning. The absence of non-diegetic music in the rock-throwing scene gives priority to the authentic sounds of the environment laughter, footsteps, rocks clattering. This decision situates the viewer in the moment, making the experience immediate and sensory. Later in the film, Burnett uses blues and gospel music to convey emotional depth, but here, silence and ambient sound do the same work. In these moments the music functions as a sound bridge leading either into or out of the more "documentary" sequences(Massood, 1999:31).

The rhythmic structure of the scene resembles the improvisational quality of jazz moments of tension followed by release, of chaos resolved by harmony. This rhythm mirrors the larger structure of the film, which unfolds through vignettes rather than a traditional plot. Each scene, like a note or a beat, contributes to a larger emotional composition. In this way, the rock-throwing scene becomes a kind of overture, a statement of the film's central theme, that tenderness and rhythm exist even in hardship.

The rock-throwing scene thus carries dual significance; it is both a record of reality and a declaration of autonomy. It asserts that Black life, even in poverty, contains beauty, humour, and complexity qualities often denied by mainstream film. In this sense, the children's play is also symbolic of creative survival: they make something out of nothing, just as Burnett made a masterpiece out of scarcity.

Charles Burnett's *Killer of Sheep* transforms the ordinary into the profound. Through its neorealist style and its attention to the textures of everyday life, the film reveals how love and tenderness endure within poverty and neglect. The rock-throwing scene, in particular, encapsulates the film's essence:

children turning ruin into play, creating rhythm and connection amid decay. Burnett's patient observation, his sensitivity to sound and light, and his focus on community allow the viewer to witness the resilience of Black life in Watts.

Beyond its aesthetic achievements, *Killer of Sheep* aligns with the principles of Third Cinema, a movement that sought to use film as a tool of cultural and political liberation. Third Cinema rejected commercial entertainment and colonial representation, aiming instead to depict the lives and struggles of oppressed communities with honesty and agency. Many Third Cinema filmmakers were driven by a political desire to break from a colonial past, rejecting dominant cinematic conventions in order to create a film style that reflected their own national contexts(Massood, 1999:25). Burnett's film, made outside the Hollywood system and produced with minimal resources, embodies this spirit of independence. Solanas and Getino (1970) write that, in its attempt to challenge popular film aesthetics, the film finds itself falling more and more under the Third Cinema movement, which can suggest that by challenging the Hollywood aesthetics, *Killer of Sheep* also fits under the umbrella of the Third Cinema Movement.

Third cinema is both destructive and creative, it dismantles the false images that neocolonialism has built of itself and of us, while constructing a vibrant, living reality that seeks to reclaim truth in all its forms (Solanas&Getino,1970). Charles Burnett's representation of Watts is not one of despair, but of dignity. By showing the ordinary lives of Black Americans with nuance and respect, Burnett challenges the dominant narratives of American cinema. His camera does not exploit suffering but reveals humanity. The choice to centre the film on daily gestures, play, work, and conversation becomes a radical act of visibility. In the context of 1970s America, where mainstream media often ignored or misrepresented Black experience, Burnett's realism is both aesthetic and political resistance.

In conclusion, like the neorealist films, *Killer of Sheep* is both poetic and political, a portrait of the human spirit that resists erasure. By aligning with the goals of Third Cinema, Burnett gives voice to those often unseen, showing that tenderness is itself a form of resistance. The film invites us to find beauty not in perfection, but in endurance in laughter, dust, and the small acts of care that keep a community alive. In *Killer of Sheep*, the ordinary is sacred, and in the quiet rhythm of a children's game, we see the heartbeat of a people who continue to love, despite everything.

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